City of Pasadena - Town Hall Meeting (2025-10-24)

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Person 1 0:00
Good evening, ladies and gentlemen. Thank you all for coming out on this Wednesday night. You're taking part of history tonight, and I want to share what that history is. We are having a town hall meeting with all of our directors for the first time in Pasadena's history. So you are part of history tonight. As your mayor, this marks our first town hall meeting ever. This is an opportunity to bring our community together, to share progress and continue building trust through open communication. I'm proud of what's been accomplished in the first hundred days of my administration and even more excited about the work that's going to take place in the upcoming weeks, months, and years.

Person 1 0:58
We have accomplished quite a bit in the last three and a half months. And some of those accomplishments I'm going to share this evening. We are we have launched a a program called Pasadena Progress, which to me is Pasadena first, because we're highlighting accomplishments that have taken place the prior week on Fridays. So we're having weekly updates on social media where we started to provide timely information regarding citywide projects. We're providing updates, highlighting improvements, and and vital information and future projects. That's quite an accomplishment for our social media team. Going out in the community, visiting with residents, Also too, with that, they're putting all that information together in a timely format and delivering it to you, our citizens, so you know exactly what's happening in our community.

Person 1 2:10
We're showcasing the outstanding work our city employees and our partners are achieving throughout our city and to make our city a better place to live and work. I would like to highlight also our quality of life projects, updating our city parks, ball fields, and also to our soccer fields. One of our directors that is here tonight, I would like to personally recognize him, Jason Ross is our parks director. As you go through tonight, please stop by and visit with Jason. Jason has and his team have done a remarkable job since he's taken this position. So please visit with Jason. And as we move forward, this is an exciting one for me, and I really don't need a whole lot of notes for this one, but it's our permitting department.

Person 1 3:11
How many of y'all have ever had an issue with a permit or a license? Quite a few. Quite a few of us. So this is what's taken place in the last three and a half months. The staffing at the permit window was increased. We also, too, evaluated the hours that our permit department was open, realizing that our department was not open during the lunch hour. Does that make sense not having a department open during the lunch hour for folks to come in and take care of business? Sometimes folks, that's the only opportunity they have is when they take off work or, you know, they need that extra time because they can't get there after work or they live out of town. They can swing by during their lunch hour. Well, we did that and we found out one obstacle. We

found out that we were short with people manning the windows at the permit department.

Person 1 4:14
So we hired a couple more folks at the window to help service our customers and I am happy to report our permit department is heading in the right direction. So I would like to give those folks a uh an opportunity for y'all to say thank you. I will continue to evaluate our permit department. We have lots of opportunities there. But I want to share one thing about our permit department before we move on. Permitting is is the window there, and permitting gets a lot of criticism, I will say this, but there's other divisions and other departments that tie into our permitting department. You have to realize our planning department and also too our engineering department, they're key factors factors in what goes on behind those windows when somebody comes in for a permit.

Person 1 5:16
So we have effectively worked together and partnered with planning, engineering, and our permit department so that they can better utilize their tools and their skills to expedite permits going forward. We have multiple success stories of folks that have run into an obstacle and we have worked through that obstacle and helped those folks move forward with their business opening or getting a permit. The next thing I'd like to share is our code updates and and changes. We found when we went in that many of our municipal codes and building code standards were not up to date. Some of them were anywhere from five to ten years out of date. So what would happen is when somebody would come in and ask for a building use permit or a land use permit or landscaping, different types of permits, our municipal codes were not up to date.

Person 1 6:28
So I instructed a team to come together. I want to thank our City Secretary's office, all the departments that were involved in getting our municipal codes up to date. We've got our municipal codes up to date on our social media so folks can go in and not have to regress when they turn their plans in. Because we all know what time is money, correct? So if you're a business owner and you're not doing the work up to the current codes, you're going to get a note back saying that you've got to go back and make a revision. That's a time gobbler that costs you time and money. So the newest international building codes, they were updated and approved so that we can move our city forward. We should start to see a big turnaround within our permit department because city codes and international codes have been updated. Our next update is is I want to take this and and kind of just share everyone that you see around the wall here at a table is one of my directors here for the city.

Person 1 7:45
This is the first time in Pasadena's history that all of the city directors are here. They're here to support you, our citizens. They're here because they care. They're here because they want to hear from you. And they want you to share with them opportunities that will make us better. Many of our department functions cross over each other, like I was sharing with the permit department. This is an opportunity for them to work together to help expedite and fix problems within our community A lot of these folks, they they didn't even know who the other directors were. They all work on different floors. They might interact over a telephone or an email, but the amazing

thing is they're putting a name and a face to a person and they're building a relationship with each other. And I want to commend our directors for doing that.

Person 1 8:48

Your enthusiasm is making our city better and you're helping our residents to achieve great things. So I would like for y'all to recognize our directors.

Person 1 9:04

One of the most important things that that I did is we went in and we started having director meetings. Can you imagine an organization where your leadership doesn't meet? How do you ever accomplish anything? How do you ever, you know, share your goals or your visions to make your organization or your community better? We sat down, our first one was uh uh July in August. We just recently had one uh here a couple of weeks ago. Our first one I laid out expectations and visions for for our city. The second one, get this, our directors came prepared and they were the ones that initiated the meeting and they were sharing ideas. That's growth. When you give folks the freedom to grow and to share, our city becomes better.

Person 1 10:04

So I want to commend them for participating and making the directors meeting a huge success. Our next one will be in January, mid-January, and we will come together and we will uh align ourselves and move forward with progress. And then our next uh accomplishment that we set out to to work on and to fix is our city website. How many of y'all have ever gone and looked at our city website? Okay, so let's be honest, that's why we're here. Our city website is very outdated. Would y'all agree with that? It is. We are currently y you know, I just thought going in and fixing a website was going in and typing in a few things and, you know, putting some new pictures on there. But I tell you what, there's a lot more involved than doing all that. There's behind-the-scene work that you have to do, code you got to put in.

Person 1 11:05

It's pretty extensive. So we we've got a format or a plan of what we want our final product to look like. But our goal is to have it up and running by the end of the year, first of the year, and we want to make it accessible for everybody. So if you're wanting to request a permit, you're going to be amazed, you're going to get to go to our website to request a permit online. How incredible is that? That is such a time saver. You don't have to drive 45 minutes, an hour and a half to get to the permit department to fill out a permit request. So engineering plans, different things like that will be able to be submitted toward the end of the year, first part of next year. And it's going to be a complete redesign. It's going to be functional and it's going to be accessible.

Person 1 12:06

Boards and commissions. How many of y'all would like to apply to serve on a board or on a commission? Okay, we got a couple. Here's the the really cool thing is that when those positions become open, you will be able to fill out an application and submit that application with your qualifications and then it will be determined, you know, the best fit for our boards and commissions. So that really provides a lot of transparency. We're looking to get people from all over the city to to serve on these boards. That's why we're opening up and trying to fix our our our website. How many of y'all have tried to contact a person because the phone number on the website is there and you call and it's not that person. There we go, we got one over here. We're

updating all of the contact information so that it's new and current There's people on the list that, quite frankly, some have passed away, some have not been with the city for years, and we need to make sure that everybody is accessible.

Person 1 13:22

Would you all agree with that with that. So our next update is our Convention Center, and you're sitting in it tonight. So our Convention Center is part of our history here in Pasadena. Our convention center is in need of being updated and refreshed. When I came into office, I was stunned to find out that the project that was going on at our convention center right next to this wall right here was $85 million over budget. That's quite a bit. Our original budget was $50 million, and it turned out that it was going to end up costing $135 million. So right now you're seeing some work over here that is kind of stalled, and I'll tell you the reason why. I'm going to be up front with you. I decided to make the hard call and say we're not going to spend $85 extra million dollars.

Person 1 14:30

We're going to bring the project within budget for $50 million. As of right now, we have a architect that is uh in the design process. Once we get the designs for the new facility here, we will have meetings, we will share it with the public and we will let you be a part of it. So we've already met with uh some of the stakeholders here in Pasadena. We've met with San Jack College, we've met with business and industry, we've met with the Rodeo Strawberry Festival, PISD, Deer Park ISD to see what the best product would be for our convention center here. And to stay true to our roots here in Pasadena, our convention center needs to be a place where industry and community can come together. We need to have the exhibit space that we need.

Person 1 15:31

We need to have exhibit rooms that function as meeting rooms for for conferences. Think about it, folks. We have the Houston Ship Channel just north of us on 225. We have Bayport to the east of us. We have NASA Road 1 and the bay to the south of us. Who are we? We are in an international city. We are the second largest city in Harris County. Harris County is the third largest county in the nation on any given day, we're number 15 to 17 in population in the state of Texas. We're bigger than most cities throughout the whole United States. We are a community that's built on white-collar and blue-collar workers, and we are a community that is like family. We're a large city, but we're a family.

Person 1 16:34

So this building needs to represent that. So with the redesign, we're looking at anywhere from 18 to 24 months. We've got to factor in weather, but you're going to start seeing activity at the convention center here soon, and it'll be something that you can be really proud of as we bring industry in and we partner with all of our stakeholders. So So that was a major undertaking, you know, to get to the point where we said we're going to save the taxpayers money because that money had to come from somewhere. So we recognize that our taxpayers are the most important folks in this city. Industry is excited about what we're doing. Pasadena School District, Deer Park School District, and Sanjak College are very are very excited about what we're doing. So please be patient.

Person 1 17:35

Even though the work has kind of slowed, the work is still going on and it's going to be a wonderful, wonderful project. Our next update is is our city hall and our city uh council chambers. So we took down the barrier that was there between the seats and the council men, women. And the reason for that is because I didn't want any barriers between our our citizens and our council members and myself. You know, we want to project transparency. We want our community to know that we're here for you. I'm here for you, our council members are here for you, so I didn't want any separation. And there's a perception that that kind of diminished the security during council members, and I'll tell you here right now that's that's that's not true.

Person 1 18:39

We have officers that maintain the building, and that is a very, very safe place to come and conduct and conduct uh your your business with city council. I also started conducting uh workshops for our city council members and for our directors to participate in. And we just finished up with what we call a a CIP workshop. That's a capital improvement plan. And so what that looks at is our goals, our needs, our desires for about the next five years. So council members were encouraged to bring to the meeting their top five needs in their district. And what we did, we worked with our budget department and all the other directors, and these things are starting to get prioritized. Now, some of them we can do, some of them we may have to wait on, but this is an opportunity for all of us to get together and have one vision and one goal.

Person 1 19:45

Their input was very valuable. Each one of them represented an area in this city. They represent their constituents. And so they should know what areas need improvements. Tell you what, kind of learned uh some things and shared it with uh council members and different folks in the workshop. Do you know it costs about three million dollars plus for one mile of road? That's quite an expense. You think, okay, you just go out there and you tear up the concrete and you put new concrete down. Well, you got to do what's under the concrete, you got to do the utilities, sewer lines. I mean, there's a lot involved when you replace uh portions of a street. So with our budget, we're going to be able to do more projects within our city. So those are things that'll be coming soon. um here we go council chambers upgrading them a lot of folks have commented and we've listened and you said why are these council meetings being not streamed live?

Person 1 21:01

Well, the reason we didn't stream them live is because we didn't have the technology to do it. So we've gone in and I've instructed our team we're going to have live streaming. It'll take place by the end of the year, first part of next year. All of our council member meetings will be live streamed. That's quite an advancement. We will also have live streaming capacity not only on Channel 16, but also too in our foyer, and we're upgrading the monitor systems out in the foyer and also in uh chamber can uh in in council chambers so that folks can actually see what's on the monitors. Uh they're they're really small and outdated, so we're updating our technology for city council chambers. And then finally, our city secretaries, our city secretaries perform quite a incredible mission or job for our community.

Person 1 22:09

They respond to requests, they prepare agendas, they work with all the directors. So we're giving them the the technology to work more efficiently. It takes quite a bit of work to to put an agenda

together, to post amendment, so we're giving them the technology to perform their job so that they can become more productive. And then finally I want to say thank you. Thank you for coming tonight. We have all of our directors here. I know many of y'all have questions. Please visit with our directors. They're going to be able to take notes tonight. They may even be able to give you an answer tonight. But the purpose of this, number one, was to have our directors here and present so that you can put a name and a face together.

Person 1 23:10

These are folks that are passionate about our city and they work very hard. So as we leave tonight, I encourage you to to visit with them. I'm going to be available to visit. And I just want to say God bless y'all and thank y'all for coming tonight.

Person 2 23:33

How are you guys doing today? Good, great. Is there anything we can do better for y'all? Are you all happy with the parks and and recreation we have in the the community? This is phenomenal. There's a lot of people in the community that are coming out. We're getting a lot of great feedback and uh this is something that's really gonna make an impact so we're excited.

Person 3 23:49

As long as you give me a heads up and we'll work it out so I can get the other group in there to do what they gotta do from the inside out. Okay. Appreciate it. Thank you. You got a lot of people coming out that never talked to any of us before. This is the time for them to come find out what we're about. You know, they get to actually meet us, talk with

Person 4 24:11

Oh, I thought it was amazing. I think he did a great job um expressing how he was going to update the city to get to more modern times because things have kind of been set back for many years and things are moving ahead. I see it going that way, so it's gonna be

Person 5 24:26

good. Okay, so having a town hall meeting is an excellent opportunity for the citizens to come out and ask us questions that they might not otherwise have an opportunity to do and to meet some of our officers. Good turnout. A lot of people here asking a lot of different questions.

Person 6 24:44

We'd love to hear from our citizens. If they have any questions regarding any issues that are happening around our city, we want to talk to them. They can come up here and we'll be more than happy to answer any of their questions, any concerns they may have regarding any public safety issue. It's a great event for that.

Person 7 25:00

Well man, it's great to get in front of them. You know, there were some of them that I'd already kind of had a an eye out for wanting to talk to and it was great to see them and meet them. Uh they answered all the questions that I had, gave me the contact info for people that I need to get in touch with.

Person 4 25:11

Oh yeah, absolutely. Yeah, proud of the permit department, health department, all the departments. They're amazing and I'm glad they're working together now.

Person 2 25:21

It's really important to a lot of families and it's something that we we realize is a need in the community. So it's actually really nice to hear that feedback from y'all. So

Person 8 25:29

learned a lot about the different departments, learned a lot what the mayor has done since he'd been in office. And uh I think it's just great. Hopefully he'll do this more often..